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# SANER ELEMENTS FEEL APPREHENSIVE ABOUT SPEAKING AGAINST THE UNWANTED IMPOSITION OF RELIGION IN PUBLIC DOMAIN

**B**eing a Muslim in India evokes mixed feelings today. Muslims are equal citizens in our democratic, secular state. They live amicably with their neighbours belonging to different religious communities. At times, these relations are ruptured and communal violence occurs, mostly between Muslims and Hindus. Significantly, Muslims do not have any serious problem with other religious communities in India. But a section of the Hindu commu-

lies in the past. Muslim presence in India goes back to over a millennium-and-a-half. Over the centuries, Muslim migrants gradually adapted themselves to the Indian milieu. This assimilative process gave rise to a syncretic pattern in life. Often this pattern was criticised by the fanatical elements of both communities, but without a wide effect till 1857. After the revolt of 1857, colonial policies tended to project Muslims and Hindus in India as two "irreconcilable and warring" communities, leading later to the "two-nation theory". The communal divide culminated in the Partition, preceded and succeeded by a communal holocaust of the worst kind.

The emergence of India as a modern nation-state saw two parallel ideologies: "inclusive", which assured equal rights to all citizens and, "exclusive", which maintained that followers of a particular faith ought to enjoy a privileged status. The Constitution reflected the spirit of the

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nity—thankfully a small one—has had a rather long history of problems with them. It is this section that has been demonising the Muslims and projecting them as terrorists and polygamists with an undesirably high birth rate. A sizeable section among the Muslims feels that they have been marginalised in almost all spheres of life in the past six decades. This feeling has been played up by various individuals and groups due to which the mistrust between some sections of Hindus and Muslims continues to grow.

What lies behind this malady? The answer

former principle, but administrative measures and policies have fallen short of those expectations and given rise to a feeling of deprivation among certain sections of Muslims. The largely secular way of life has suffered a setback. Saner elements—in both communities—feel apprehensive about speaking against the unwanted imposition of religion in public domain. The remedy lies perhaps in reverting to the message of devotion to God, coupled with peace and harmony among fellow beings, which is an integral part of the Indian ethos. **As told to Farzand Ahmed**